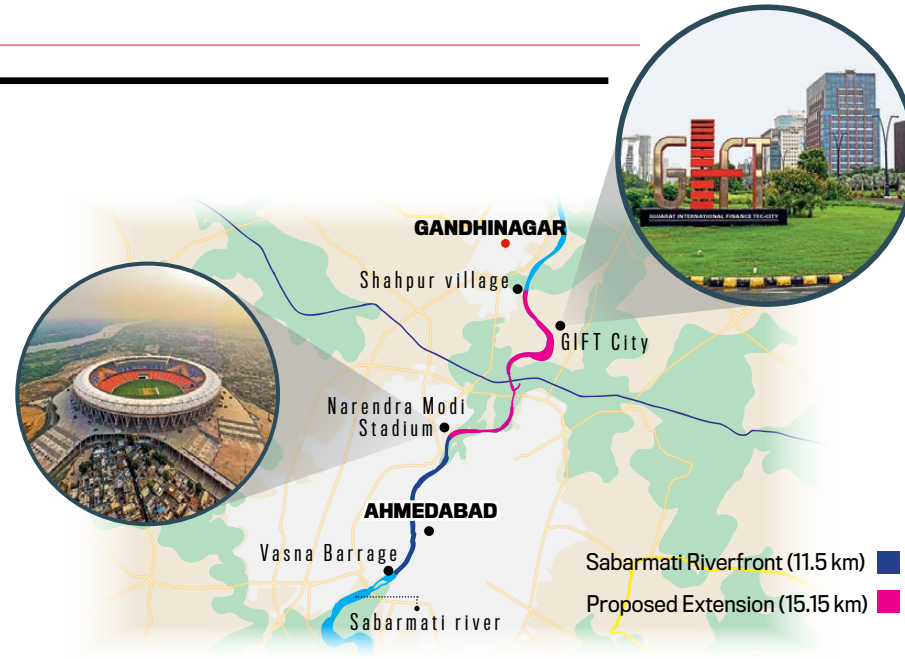
vibrant and well-planned metropolis to attract talent and creativity," says Keshav Varma, chairman of the Sabarmati Riverfront Development Corporation Ltd (SRFDCL), a special purpose vehicle formed in 1997 to plan and oversee the project. Its officials say the extension will generate 135 hectares of new land, creating a special space that will transform the river into a "focal point of leisure and recreation" for those residing within 10 km.

But there may be a gap between vision and reality, especially seeing how the first phase went. The 204 hectares of land reclaimed then from the riverbed was meant to be auctioned to realtors for commercial and residential development, but the idea did not find many takers. The SRFDCL has now come up with the revised Sabarmati Riverfront Land Disposal Policy, 2023, which will do away with residential, bring down commercial, and instead focus on open spaces, public amenities and recreational facilities.

That said, even recreational facilities have failed to generate much interest. The seaplane service that Prime Minister Narendra Modi had inaugurated with much fanfare ahead of the 2017 assembly election was shut down in 2021. A sports park, readied in 2020, was handed over to an Adani Group firm recently after lying idle for three years. The area does see a high footfall of locals and tourists seeking open spaces for leisure and activities like boating and kayaking, but much of the stretch continues to lack vibrant cafes and cultural centres, typical of riverfronts abroad. Among the reasons realtors cite for this sluggish uptake is that the commercial district has moved further west while the government is giving out land at high rates in an area that is no longer the heart of the city.

SRFDCL officials insist there is no dearth of enthusiasm among realtors, and the revised policy will breathe new life into the project. But why tenders floated multiple times for development were withdrawn remains a mystery.



HURDLES AHEAD

- **The Sabarmati riverfront is being extended from 11.5 km to 26.65 km; will run seamlessly from Ahmedabad to Gandhinagar**
- **The biggest challenge is the river itself. The Sabarmati is not perennial and is also facing acute pollution**
- **The loss of natural floodplains is also a cause of concern**
- **A proper plan is needed to rehabilitate people who will be affected by the project**
- **And all this has to be done keeping in mind the tight deadline of 2026 to complete the first 5.5-km stretch of the extension project**

Prof. Navdeep Mathur, an urban planning expert at the Indian Institute of Management, Ahmedabad, also flags concern about the rehabilitation of people affected by the first phase and the loss of natural floodplains due to the construction of concrete walls on the reclaimed land. "Thousands of people lost their livelihoods," he says. "The rehabilitated colonies lack basic civic infrastructure like schools and health facilities. One hopes this is not repeated." The second phase alone will require the relocation of "a few hundred families", says an official on the condition of anonymity, while the survey for the remaining phases is awaited.

But the biggest challenge for the project comes from, well, the river itself. The Sabarmati is not perennial. Currently, water is diverted into the river from the Narmada main canal at Karai while the Vasna barrage at the southern end keeps it within the confines of the city. Once the riverfront is extended, the same outfall of the canal will be utilised to divert water upstream by creating a barrage near Motera. Water will also be supplied from the Dharoi dam in Mehsana in the north. It's not exactly a Venice.

That's not the only worry. Untreated industrial effluents and domestic sewage have endlessly polluted the Sabarmati. A 210-km-long marine outfall is in the works to discharge the effluents from industrial clusters in Ahmedabad directly into the Gulf of Khambhat. But even that will take at least a decade to fructify. ■